

Chaos at AIRPORTS

Low fares helped make air travel a reality for many. But the massive boom has exposed the ugly underbelly of aviation infrastructure. Serpentine queues at counters, filthy airports and hours lost in air and on the ground have made flying a nightmare.

Delhi

- A two-hour Delhi-Mumbai flight can take up to four hours, thanks to congestion
- Aircraft hover over airports for 15-30 minutes before they are allotted a landing slot
- Capacity of 13 million passengers, but handles 23 million passengers

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

It's an hour before midnight on a Tuesday at the Indira Gandhi International Airport in Delhi and hordes of passengers pour through the terminal that's under renovation and plastered with posters that say "A world class airport awaits you".

Underneath that optimistic message from the Delhi International Airport Ltd (DIAL) in smaller type is another line, "Until then, the inconvenience is regretted". Meant to act as a balm, the glib line only adds to the ire of the traveller. The competitive pushing needed to negotiate trolleys and gaping crowds, suffering the queues at the check-in counters and bearing with the crawl at immigration counters makes reaching the seat in the aircraft an Olympian achievement. But there is more. Your flight could be behind 20 others and you could still be on

the ground, four hours after stepping into the airport. Thanks to the lack of runways, air traffic control operators or a dog that could have grounded a taxiing aircraft. Between them, airlines, airport developers and the government machinery have combined to engineer a new fear of flying.

On a typical night at the Delhi airport, at any given time there are over 10,000 passengers—elderly Sikhs flying to Canada, Buddhist monks en

route to Japan, students, tourists, young couples and stressed-out executives who will take home horror tales of their Indian airport experiences. Packed like sardines in a can called the holding area awaiting immigration clearance, their anxious eyes scan wristwatches and the flight information table before them. There are only 28 immigration counters of which only 18 are manned by officials from the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA). At peak